

Directional Responsibility–Role Obligation Cross

***Responsibility Vectors, Competing Duties, and
Burden Allocation in Role-Bound Systems***

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Abstract

This document formalizes the **Directional Responsibility–Role Obligation Cross** as a structural framework for analyzing responsibility as a configuration of role-based obligations rather than a single undifferentiated attribute. The Cross begins from a basic question: responsibility toward whom, for what, from which role, under which priority, and at whose expense?

Actors, offices, institutions, interfaces, and technical systems can carry obligations in multiple directions. These may point upward toward authority, downward toward dependents, outward toward publics, inward toward institutional continuity, laterally toward peers, procedurally toward rules, technically toward system performance, or epistemically toward source and evidence quality. Different directions can reinforce one another, conflict, or remain invisible.

A system may appear responsible in one direction while shifting burden or neglect into another. Compliance with procedure can conceal harm to affected parties. Public-facing responsibility can coexist with hidden internal labor. Technical correctness can be treated as complete responsibility even when answerability or access remains unresolved. Conversely, attempting to satisfy every direction without sequencing or support can produce integrative responsibility overload.

The Cross does not define moral goodness, legal liability, or a leadership typology. It provides a language for locating the direction, target, role basis, and tension field of responsibility claims. This makes it possible to analyze how obligations shape action, which duties dominate, and where burden is displaced when multiple responsibilities cannot be satisfied simultaneously.

Keywords

Directional Responsibility; Role Obligation; Responsibility Vector; Competing Duties; Responsibility Target; Role Position; Burden Allocation; Procedural Responsibility; Technical Responsibility; Epistemic Responsibility; Obligation Conflict; Responsibility Alignment; Meta-Writing Ecology.

1. Introduction

Responsibility is frequently treated as if it were a substance that an actor either possesses or lacks. This framing hides the directional structure of obligation. A role can be highly responsive to one target and inattentive to another. A decision can satisfy the institution above while transferring risk to users below. A system can protect technical reliability while weakening public contestability.

The Cross treats responsibility as a vector. The relevant unit is not only the responsible actor but the relation between role, obligation, target, priority, action, and consequence. This allows apparently contradictory judgments to be decomposed rather than collapsed into a general moral label.

The framework is especially useful in multi-role systems where duties point in different directions and no single action can satisfy them all. It does not resolve the conflict automatically. It makes the configuration visible enough for explicit choice and support.

2. Core Definition

Directional Responsibility–Role Obligation Cross describes a condition in which responsibility does not function as a single moral attribute, but as a directional configuration of perceived obligations attached to roles, targets, and action priorities.

The Cross appears when an actor, system, office, institution, model, or interface is described as “responsible,” but the relevant question is not simply whether responsibility exists.

The relevant question is:

Responsible toward whom? Responsible for what? Responsible from which role position? Responsible under which obligation direction? Responsible at whose expense?

In this Cross, responsibility is treated as a vector rather than a substance.

A role-bearing actor may hold obligations in multiple directions:

upward downward outward inward lateral procedural public technical
institutional relational

Different responsibility directions can reinforce one another, conflict with one another, or obscure one another.

A person, office, AI system, organization, or interface may appear responsible in one direction while displacing burden, risk, neglect, or accountability in another.

The core structure is:

role position → perceived obligation → responsibility direction → target priority →
action logic → responsibility configuration

3. Classification and Scope

This document presents **Directional Responsibility–Role Obligation Cross** as a Cross. A Cross identifies a stable intersection among existing mechanisms, roles, or system conditions. Its function is to preserve the distinct source structures while making their interaction analyzable. It should not be converted into a standalone model merely because the intersection is recurrent.

The Cross is external-facing and conceptual. It does not establish empirical prevalence, legal duty, technical compliance, or a universal evaluation rule. The public version omits non-public editorial records, private source materials, non-public working materials, and implementation details.

4. Central Distinctions

This Cross records:

the structural configuration of responsibility across role-bound obligation directions

It does not record:

general moral responsibility legal liability personal virtue leadership personality ethical excellence good intention stakeholder preference alone ordinary accountability formal job description alone

The Cross applies when responsibility must be understood by locating its direction, target, role basis, and competing obligations.

5. Core Mechanism and Structural Sequence

5.1 Core Mechanism

role position × perceived obligation × responsibility target × action priority ×
tension management = directional responsibility configuration

Expanded mechanism:

1. An actor occupies a role within a social, technical, institutional, organizational, or procedural system.
2. The role carries explicit or implicit obligations.
3. The actor interprets those obligations directionally: toward superiors, subordinates, peers, users, publics, rules, systems, sources, future conditions, or the actor's own mandate.
4. One or more responsibility directions become dominant.
5. Action priorities are shaped by the dominant obligation direction.
6. Other responsibility directions may be weakened, deferred, subordinated, displaced, or treated as secondary.
7. The actor or system may still appear responsible, but only within a specific direction of obligation.
8. The responsibility configuration generates tensions, blind spots, legitimating narratives, and burden allocations.

5.2 Structural Sequence

role position
→ multiple obligations become active
→ responsibility directions are differentiated
→ one or more targets receive priority
→ action is organized around the dominant direction
→ other obligations are deferred, weakened, or displaced
→ burdens and benefits are redistributed
→ the resulting responsibility claim is evaluated by direction rather than by label alone

6. Structural Components

1. Role Position

a location within a system that carries rights, duties, expectations, authority, exposure, or accountability

A role may be formal or informal.

Examples:

manager reviewer developer operator moderator teacher administrator public official system designer AI assistant platform interface institutional gatekeeper technical evaluator

The role determines which obligations can become active.

2. Perceived Obligation

the actor's internal or operational sense that some target must be answered, protected, served, optimized, preserved, or prioritized

Perceived obligation may arise from:

formal mandate organizational expectation professional norm personal belief system instruction public pressure technical objective risk exposure relational dependence governance requirement

The Cross does not require that the perceived obligation be morally correct.

It only requires that the obligation shape behavior.

3. Responsibility Direction

the vector toward which responsibility is aimed

Possible directions include:

upward responsibility toward authority, mandate, superior, funder, owner, institution, or performance target

downward responsibility toward subordinates, dependents, users, affected parties, or those under care

outward responsibility toward society, public welfare, environment, future stakeholders, or external legitimacy

inward responsibility toward internal coherence, integrity, self-maintenance, identity, or system survival

lateral responsibility toward peers, collaborators, adjacent units, co-actors, or shared systems

procedural responsibility toward rules, protocols, standards, auditability, or process integrity

technical responsibility toward system performance, robustness, reliability, security, or operational correctness

epistemic responsibility toward source validity, truth conditions, interpretation quality, or uncertainty marking

The specific vocabulary may vary by domain.

The structural requirement is directional differentiation.

4. Target Priority

which responsibility target becomes dominant when obligations conflict

A system may prioritize:

performance over care care over procedure procedure over outcome public legitimacy over internal welfare cost efficiency over verification user satisfaction over

source validity upward reporting over downstream harm technical optimization over institutional accountability

Target priority reveals the active responsibility configuration.

5. Tension Field

the conflict zone created when multiple obligation directions cannot be satisfied simultaneously

Tensions may arise between:

performance and care procedure and discretion public welfare and institutional survival user convenience and source validity cost reduction and verification labor organizational mandate and affected-party burden technical accuracy and relational responsibility short-term compliance and long-term legitimacy

The Cross is most visible when responsibility directions collide.

7. Primary Failure Patterns

1. Single-Direction Responsibility Inflation

responsible in one direction → treated as generally responsible

An actor fulfills one obligation direction and is then read as broadly responsible.

Example structure:

responsible to authority ≠ responsible to affected parties

2. Upward Responsibility Capture

duty to superior / funder / institution → treated as total responsibility

The actor or system satisfies the mandate above it while neglecting downstream or public consequences.

3. Downward Care Overreach

care for dependents → procedure, legitimacy, or broader effects neglected

A responsibility configuration may over-focus on immediate dependents and ignore wider structural effects.

4. Outward Legitimacy Substitution

public-facing responsibility → substitutes for internal responsibility

An organization or system performs public responsibility while ignoring internal burden, labor, or care obligations.

5. Procedural Responsibility Shielding

followed procedure → responsibility treated as discharged

The actor claims responsibility through rule compliance while substantive harm, burden, or validity remains unresolved.

6. Technical Responsibility Narrowing

system works → responsibility treated as complete

Technical success substitutes for broader responsibility toward users, affected parties, governance, or interpretation.

7. Responsibility Direction Omission

responsible actor named but direction unspecified

The discourse claims responsibility without naming who is owed responsibility or what obligation is being fulfilled.

8. Obligation Conflict Concealment

multiple duties conflict → response presents responsibility as unified

The actor or system hides responsibility tensions behind a single responsible-sounding explanation.

9. Burden Reassignment Under Responsible Form

responsible language → burden moves elsewhere

A responsible posture may relocate risk, verification work, emotional labor, or accountability to another party.

10. Integrative Responsibility Overload

all directions activated → actor lacks resources to satisfy them

A broad responsibility configuration may become unstable if no sequencing, support, or boundary mechanism exists.

Distinctions

Not the same as moral goodness

moral goodness: an evaluative claim about virtue or ethical quality.

directional responsibility: a structural claim about where responsibility is aimed and what obligations are prioritized.

Not the same as accountability

accountability: who can be called to answer.

directional responsibility: which obligation direction shaped the actor's conduct before, during, or after action.

Not the same as role division

role division: tasks or positions are separated.

directional responsibility: obligation vectors attached to roles shape priority, tension, and burden.

Not the same as stakeholder mapping

stakeholder mapping: identifies affected or relevant parties.

directional responsibility: analyzes which targets become obligation-bearing and how those obligations shape action.

Not the same as responsibility alignment

responsibility alignment: whether ownership, authority, visibility, capacity, and accountability support responsibility.

directional responsibility: where the responsibility points and which obligation target dominates.

Relation to Existing Structures

Relation to Responsibility Alignment Model

This Cross is directly adjacent to Responsibility Alignment Model.

Responsibility Alignment asks whether responsibility lands where ownership, authority, visibility, capacity, and accountability support it.

Directional Responsibility–Role Obligation asks where responsibility points and which role-based obligation direction becomes dominant.

Responsibility Alignment: Can this responsibility be properly held?

Directional Responsibility–Role Obligation: Toward whom is this responsibility oriented?

The two should remain distinct.

A responsibility direction may be clear but misaligned.

A responsibility may be aligned but still narrow in direction.

Relation to Benefit–Burden Allocation Regimes

This Cross is adjacent to Benefit–Burden Allocation Regimes.

Responsibility direction often determines where benefits and burdens land.

Example:

upward responsibility dominant → benefits may flow toward authority or
performance target → burdens may fall downward or outward

This Cross identifies the obligation vector.

Benefit–Burden Allocation identifies distributional landing.

Relation to Cost Visibility and Redistribution Model

This Cross is adjacent to Cost Visibility and Redistribution Model.

Responsibility direction can make some costs visible and others invisible.

Example:

responsibility to efficiency → visible cost reduction → invisible verification burden
downstream

The direction of responsibility shapes which costs are counted.

Relation to Boundary-Role Segmentation Model

This Cross is adjacent to Boundary-Role Segmentation Model.

Boundary-Role Segmentation concerns over-separation of roles, where local
coherence can create system-level contradiction.

Directional Responsibility–Role Obligation concerns the obligation direction
attached to a role.

role separated + obligation narrowed = responsibility tunnel

Relation to Boundary Integration Failure

This Cross is adjacent to Boundary Integration Failure.

Boundary Integration Failure occurs when roles, authority scopes, instructions, or operational layers are over-fused.

Directional Responsibility–Role Obligation intersects when multiple responsibility directions collapse into one undifferentiated “responsibility” claim.

many responsibility directions → one responsible surface → tension hidden

Relation to Source-Form Attribution Misalignment

This Cross is adjacent to Source-Form Attribution Misalignment.

A form may signal responsibility without supporting the responsibility direction it implies.

Example:

formal apology → appears outwardly responsible → actual obligation remains upward or legal-protective

The form suggests one direction.

The operative responsibility may point elsewhere.

Relation to Provenance–Validity Separation Model

This Cross is adjacent to Provenance–Validity Separation Model.

A responsibility claim may have clear provenance.

That does not establish that the responsibility direction is valid for the affected situation.

official responsibility statement ≠ valid responsibility orientation

Relation to Proxy Substitution

This Cross is adjacent to Proxy Substitution.

A proxy may stand in for responsibility.

Examples:

compliance report → proxy for responsibility

stakeholder consultation → proxy for outward responsibility

employee benefit → proxy for downward responsibility

performance metric → proxy for upward responsibility

The proxy may become the object of management while the actual obligation target remains unresolved.

Relation to Verification Labor Compression

This Cross is adjacent to Verification Labor Compression.

When responsibility direction is unspecified, users, workers, reviewers, or affected parties may need to infer who is responsible for what.

responsibility language present → directional clarity absent → verification labor transferred

Relation to Pipeline Decision–Causal Validity Cross

This Cross is adjacent to Pipeline Decision–Causal Validity Cross.

A pipeline decision may be justified as responsible, but the direction of responsibility determines what outcome is being optimized.

Example:

responsible evaluation toward cost control ≠ responsible evaluation toward affected-party validity

Causal validity asks whether the decision effect is identified.

Directional responsibility asks which obligation target the decision serves.

Relation to Situated Normativity–Generative Flattening Cross

This Cross is adjacent to Situated Normativity–Generative Flattening Cross.

Responsibility directions are often situated in roles, relations, institutions, histories, and practices.

Generative systems may flatten those directions into a generic answer such as:

be responsible act ethically balance stakeholders follow best practices

This Cross preserves the directional structure that flattening may erase.

Relation to Civic Information–Generative Interface Trust Drift Cross

This Cross is adjacent to Civic Information–Generative Interface Trust Drift Cross.

Civic interfaces may claim responsibility toward the public while operationally prioritizing platform safety, legal risk, cost control, or answer helpfulness.

This Cross asks which responsibility direction is active when civic information is mediated.

Relation to Profile-Mediated Output Alignment Cross

This Cross is adjacent to Profile-Mediated Output Alignment Cross.

A profile can encode responsibility direction.

Example:

profile optimized for user satisfaction → responsibility points toward preference fit

profile optimized for institutional risk → responsibility points toward liability reduction

profile optimized for source fidelity → responsibility points toward epistemic validity

The profile becomes an obligation-direction carrier.

Relation to Recognition Without Flattening Cross

This Cross is adjacent to Recognition Without Flattening Cross.

Recognizing responsibility without flattening requires preserving multiple obligation directions without collapsing them into a single responsible identity.

responsible actor $\neq$ all responsibility directions equally satisfied

8. Operational Evaluation

1. Which role is making or receiving the responsibility claim?
2. Toward whom or what does the obligation point?
3. Which direction becomes dominant when duties conflict?
4. What burden is displaced by that priority?
5. Does procedural or technical compliance substitute for another responsibility direction?
6. Are public responsibility claims aligned with internal labor and affected-party consequence?
7. Does the actor have authority and resources to satisfy the activated obligations?
8. Is responsibility being treated as unified when it is directionally divided?

9. Application Domains

1. Institutional decision-making

Offices may prioritize mandates, budgets, procedures, publics, staff, and affected groups differently.

2. AI and platform governance

Technical, user, provider, regulator, and public responsibilities may point toward competing targets.

3. Professional roles

Reviewers, managers, clinicians, engineers, educators, and administrators may face conflicts between procedural, relational, and epistemic duties.

4. Public communication

Outward legitimacy claims can be compared with internal burden, evidence quality, and downstream consequence.

5. Crisis and high-pressure systems

Urgency can activate one obligation direction while suppressing others that remain consequential.

10. Relations to Adjacent Public Frameworks

1. Responsibility Alignment Model

Responsibility Alignment Model clarifies whether ownership, authority, capacity, visibility, and accountability remain attached to compatible nodes. The present entry specifies one condition under which that alignment can fail or become nominal.

2. Benefit-Burden Allocation Regimes

Benefit–Burden Allocation Regimes examines where benefits, burdens, control, risk, and verification work are placed across a system. The present entry specifies a recurring allocation pattern.

3. Boundary-Role Segmentation Model

Boundary-Role Segmentation Model describes local coherence within bounded roles and the contradictions that appear across role interfaces. The present entry clarifies which roles or thresholds must be kept separate.

4. Cost Visibility and Redistribution Model

Cost Visibility and Redistribution Model tracks how costs become visible at one node and hidden or displaced at another. The present entry shows how verification, correction, access, or responsibility costs can be redistributed by the relevant interface.

5. Boundary Integration Failure

Boundary Integration Failure describes collapse produced by merging roles, instructions, or authority layers that require differentiation. The present entry identifies one layer pair that must remain distinguishable.

11. Boundary Conditions and Non-Applicability

11.1 Boundary Conditions

This Cross applies when:

1. An actor, system, institution, office, or interface occupies a role.
2. The role carries obligations toward different targets.
3. These obligations are not equally activated.

4. One or more responsibility directions shape decision-making, behavior, explanation, or evaluation.
5. The actor or system may appear responsible in one direction while creating neglect, burden, or distortion in another direction.
6. Responsibility tensions arise because obligations point toward different targets.
7. The analysis requires distinguishing responsibility direction from responsibility existence.

This Cross does not apply when:

1. Responsibility has no role basis.
2. There are no distinguishable obligation directions.
3. The issue is only legal liability.
4. The actor's responsibility target is explicit, singular, and uncontested.
5. The analysis only concerns personal morality or virtue.
6. The problem is merely workload, stress, or task overload without obligation-direction conflict.
7. Responsibility is used only as a rhetorical label and has no operational effect.

11.2 Non-Applicability

The framework should not be used as a universal criticism of the relevant technology, workflow, role, or interface. It applies to a specific structural mismatch, not to every instance of the general category.

12. Public Orientation and Method Boundary

This document is designed as a public conceptual entry. It provides a definition, mechanism, diagnostic orientation, and limit statement. It omits non-public editorial records, private source materials, non-public working materials, and implementation details.

The entry is not a substitute for empirical research, legal analysis, professional judgment, technical testing, or domain-specific governance. It should not be used to score people or institutions, automate high-stakes decisions, or infer misconduct from conceptual similarity.

Examples and application domains are illustrative. A case should be classified under **Directional Responsibility–Role Obligation Cross** only when the relevant structure can be demonstrated from available evidence.

13. Limitations

1. No moral ranking

The Cross identifies directions but does not decide which obligation is ethically superior.

2. Directions are context-dependent

Upward, downward, inward, and outward are relational terms rather than fixed categories.

3. Roles can be distributed

Collective and institutional roles may require analysis at several levels.

4. Stated duty may differ from operative duty

Formal mandates do not always reveal what actually drives action.

5. Conflict visibility does not resolve scarcity

Some responsibility tensions require resources, authority, or political choice beyond conceptual clarification.

14. Minimal Formulation

Directional Responsibility–Role Obligation occurs when responsibility is produced through the directional configuration of role-based obligations rather than through a single undifferentiated moral claim.

Shorter form:

Responsibility is not only whether one is responsible, but where responsibility points.

Even shorter:

Responsibility has direction.

Structural Formula

$\text{role} \times \text{obligation} \times \text{target} \times \text{priority} \times \text{tension} = \text{responsibility direction}$

Alternative formula:

responsibility claim

directional analysis

undifferentiated moral surface

15. Conclusion

Responsibility has direction. A claim that an actor or system is responsible remains structurally incomplete until the target, role basis, priority, and displaced burden are specified.

The Cross provides a way to compare responsibility configurations without reducing them to virtue or blame. It is most useful where one direction of obligation is being mistaken for responsibility as a whole, or where unresolved conflicts are hidden behind a unified responsible surface.

Naming Declaration

Directional Responsibility–Role Obligation Cross is a term declared within Meta-Writing Ecology.

Within Meta-Writing Ecology, it names a cross-system condition in which responsibility is understood as a directional configuration of role-based obligations rather than as a single moral attribute, general virtue, or undifferentiated accountability claim.

The term is not imported from leadership studies, role theory, business ethics, CSR theory, stakeholder theory, moral psychology, organizational behavior, public administration, AI governance, or legal accountability doctrine.

Those fields may be adjacent comparison surfaces.

They do not define the term.

In this Cross, directional responsibility refers to the vector of responsibility: the target toward which an obligation points and the priority structure that follows from that direction.

Role obligation refers to the duties, expectations, constraints, or perceived commitments attached to a role position inside a system.

The term does not claim that one responsibility direction is always superior.

It does not reduce responsibility to leadership style.

It does not classify persons by personality.

It does not function as a moral ranking scheme.

It identifies a structural condition: an actor, system, office, or interface may be responsible in one direction while neglecting, deferring, or burdening another.

The purpose of the term is to make responsibility direction visible before responsibility language is accepted as sufficient.